more about retaining its own economic power than representing and preserving Burma. Over time, it took control of key assets and ensured that any foreign investment enriched the military leadership.

But there were also frequent factional disputes over the division of the spoils and the best way to preserve military rule. These disputes within the military elite may go some way to explaining the decision to overthrow Ne Win in 1988 when it appeared that the pro-democracy movement was making gains, and also the removal of Than Shwe after 2010 when there was a need for the ruling party to appear to be part of the new democracy. Both should be seen as the outcomes of tactical disputes about how best to retain power, either by further repression or by appearing to embrace change. Neither actually mean the generals have a real commitment to democracy, or are prepared to see their real power base (and thus the source of their economic wealth) undermined.

The Burmese Road to Socialism and the strain of constant war proved to be an economic disaster. All Burmese apart from the ruling elite suffered throughout military rule,[30] and there are numerous well-documented instances of forced labour[31] and other human rights abuses. Popular anger erupted in 1987 when Ne Win decided to cancel most bank notes on the grounds that they represented unlucky numbers. The only notes left in circulation were the 45 and 90 kyat notes (Ne Win believed these were lucky numbers as they were divisible by nine).[32] This destroyed people's limited savings overnight at a time when the population was already suffering from the ongoing economic crisis.

As we have seen above, Buddhism played a complex role during the military dictatorship. It was co-opted by the state as part of the ruling ideology and the military tried to gain popular support by funding monasteries and monks in the 1970s and 1980s. On the other hand, Buddhist monks were critically important during the 1988 revolt.[33] Monks and students protested together: 'students sported their symbol of the fighting peacock, and monks carried their alms bowls upside down to show they would not accept handouts from the military, again as a protest'.[34] While the army put down the revolt by shooting at the protestors,[35] the alliance of convenience between pro-democracy demonstrators and Buddhist monks endured, and continues to have significant implications for contemporary politics in Myanmar.